



Rain 76/66 • Tomorrow: A little rain 76/68 C16

Democracy Dies in Darkness

MONDAY, MAY 25, 2026 • \$4

Shooter was facing trespassing charges

Man who fired near White House had been barred from its grounds

BY WARREN P. STROBEL,
SAMMY WESTFALL,
AARON SCHAEFFER
AND SALVADOR RIZZO

From his senior year at Dundalk High School in Baltimore County, Maryland, where he ran track for the Dundalk Owls, Nasire Best's life seemed to take one wrong turn after another, according to court records and a high school friend.

Best, who according to police was shot and killed Saturday by Secret Service officers after opening fire near the White House, had by that time cut off contact with even his closest friends and began claiming that he was Jesus Christ.

Best, 21, was described by the friend as apolitical, with a love of jokes and the video game "Fortnite," and an obsession with running.

While much about his short life remains unclear, Best had a rough senior year at Dundalk in 2023, said the friend, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to protect his privacy. He was bullied constantly and after a fight with another student, the friend said, Best was suspended, missing senior prom and part of the track season.

"Nothing really went his way," the friend said.

In May 2025, for reasons that are unclear, Best began unfollowing friends on social media, angered that they did not accept his claim he was Jesus.

Rhonda Melvin, who told The Post that Best was her son, said she was still in disbelief at the events that played out near the White House on Saturday, leading

SEE WHITE HOUSE ON A4

Russia launches major assault on Ukraine



EFREM LUKATSKY/AP

Ukrainian firefighters rest on an escalator in a subway shelter early Sunday, waiting for the end of Russia's missile and drone attacks on Kyiv. A powerful Oreshnik intermediate-range ballistic missile was fired during the strikes, which killed at least two people and injured more than 80, Kyiv's mayor said. **Story, A11**

More female troops make the ultimate sacrifice

The Iran war is unique in the proportion of women who've been wounded or killed in action

BY TARA COPP

Greg Pruitt had a surprise for his wife, Ashley. It was 2023 and the young family was about to transfer from Oklahoma's Altus Air Force Base to her next posting. Altus was special to them. It's where Ashley's military career had bloomed and so had their relationship, after Greg finally got the nerve to ask her out.

So he arranged a date, a professional photo shoot for the two of them and children Emilia, 3, and Oliver, 12. In the amber-hued

photographs of that afternoon, Ashley holds onto Greg as he dips her into the sunlight and she beams.

Last month, Greg pulled out the photos as he prepared for a celebration of Ashley's life. The technical sergeant, 34, died in March after a midair collision over Iraq between two KC-135 Air Force refueling tankers, a tragedy that unfolded as scores of aircraft crisscrossed the Middle East during the early days of the Iran war.

"She loved the responsibility

and dynamic of being part of the crew," Greg Pruitt said of his late wife. "She thrived when there was something to be done — and she knew she could do it better than most."

Ashley Pruitt is one of 13 service members killed in action since hostilities with Iran began in late February. A 14th service member died after a medical emergency in Kuwait in March. They've joined the hundreds of thousands of service members who since the United States' founding have lost their lives

defending the country, a sacrifice that is honored each Memorial Day.

What's unique about this conflict is the proportion of female troops who've been wounded or killed. In the Iraq and Afghanistan wars, women accounted for about 2 percent of all American combat casualties. They account for 12 percent — 47 out of 405 — of those wounded by Iranian counterattacks, according to Pentagon records, and 23 percent — three of 13 — of those who

SEE MEMORIAL DAY ON A2

Crucial phase of talks reached

U.S., IRAN PUSH FOR PACT TO END WAR

Deal to extend ceasefire, open Hormuz is near

BY SAMMY WESTFALL,
NATALIE ALLISON,
JOHN HUDSON
AND SUSANNAH GEORGE

The United States and Iran have developed a memorandum of understanding "framework" that extends the ceasefire 60 days as the two sides reach a "final deal" to permanently end the war in Iran, but in the meantime would result in the Strait of Hormuz being demined and reopened, a senior administration official said.

The official, however, said no agreement with Iran had been signed on Sunday. It remains unclear how binding the current framework is.

A diplomat familiar with the matter, who like others for this story spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss ongoing negotiations, said the latest proposal is currently awaiting the approval of the Iranians.

Upon signing the memorandum of understanding, Iran would immediately reopen the Strait of Hormuz and take steps to ensure the traffic returns to prewar conditions within 30 days, the latest proposal stipulates, according to the diplomat. It also would see Iran, the U.S. and allies declaring that military operations on every front, including Lebanon, end immediately.

SEE IRAN ON A12

Rubio: Secretary of state defends Iran deal from critics in GOP. **A12**

Deadly disease's weakness was long elusive — until now

Scientists cracked a key target in treating pancreatic cancer

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

For decades, one of the deadliest cancers had an Achilles' heel lying in plain sight.

Pancreatic cancer is an exquisitely cruel diagnosis, leaving only 13 percent of people alive after five years. But in the early 1980s, scientists discovered a weakness — a mutated protein called KRAS — that spurred the aggressive growth and spread an array of tumors. In pancreatic cancer, it would turn out to be a key driver of nearly every case.

There was just one problem. The KRAS protein they needed to block was flat and smooth, without the crevices and cracks, pockets and sockets that a drug needs to get a foothold.

Scientists came up with various nicknames. A bowling ball with no holes. A greasy ball. Undruggable. The elephant in the room for cancer research — everyone knows it's there, nobody wants to deal with it.

No longer.

In the span of a few weeks, the conventional wisdom on pancreatic cancer and KRAS has been upended. In April, biotech com-

pany Revolution Medicines announced that its experimental pill, called daraxonrasib, had notched an unprecedented success — patients lived for 13 months, twice as long as those given regular chemotherapy. The full details will be presented this weekend at the American Society of Clinical Oncology meeting in Chicago, but federal regulators have already expanded access to the drug while it is being reviewed.

"It's the start of a huge wave for this disease," said Eileen O'Reilly, a gastrointestinal medical oncologist at Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center. Following behind are other drugs that may work better and the potential to use the approach against lung and colorectal cancers.

To the public, the advance arrived like many revolutions in science — out of the blue. Ben Sasse, the former U.S. senator from Nebraska, drew attention to the drug in an interview with the New York Times. But this success is the end product of decades of meticulous, unglamorous, brute-force chemistry. It also required the bravery of patients like Alyson Luck, an art educator, wife and mom of two young children who was diagnosed with Stage 4 pancreatic cancer in 2022.

Luck was one of the participants in an early clinical trial testing daraxonrasib. She died in

SEE PANCREATIC CANCER ON A7



JESSICA PONS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Still chasing her dreams

Elsie Saldaña, 81, also known as the drag king El Daña, performs at the Virgil in Los Angeles this month. Last year, Guinness World Records recognized her as the oldest drag king in America. Six decades into her career, Saldaña is still hoping for her big break. **Story, A3**

Inside Silicon Valley's push to rebrand doping as wellness

BY ELIZABETH DWOSKIN
AND RICK MAESE

LAS VEGAS — This past week, in a city built on risk and reward, billionaire biohacker Christian Angermayer went about his wellness routine.

He injected himself with weight loss drugs, testosterone, and legal-

but-off-label growth hormones, designed to reduce deep layers of fat and regenerate his cells. To feel more outgoing, he added the peptide oxytocin, typically used by doctors to stimulate labor. For focus, he popped a pill of his usual stimulant, normally prescribed for sleep apnea. He logged tens of thousands of steps, sprinting to

meetings at his hotel and doing circles around a large swimming pool.

Angermayer was getting ready to show the world that the experimental health protocols embraced by longevity-obsessed business elites like himself can work for top athletes — and, ultimately, the entire world.

Angermayer, who at 48 looks a decade younger, is the co-founder and funder of the Enhanced Games, a Silicon Valley-backed athletic tournament that breaks a cardinal rule of sports by encouraging athletes to take steroids, hormones, peptides and any legal performance-enhancing drug.

SEE ENHANCED ON A16

IN THE NEWS

Hoping for a shift Democrat Sherrod Brown lost his Senate seat in a Trump wave, but he is trying to persuade Ohioans to send him back to Washington just two years later. **A5**

United against vermin The candidates in this year's primary elections in D.C. can all agree on one thing: The rats need to go. **C7**

THE NATION

The risk of an explosion caused by a damaged chemical tank in California has abated, but an evacuation order for more than 50,000 people remains in effect, officials said. **A6**

THE WORLD

The Catholic Church sees Africa as central to its growth, but Pope Leo XIV's recent visit came at a time when Pentecostal churches on the continent are growing more quickly. **A10**

THE ECONOMY

New graduates who studied computer science are starting careers just as AI is upending the job market. **A12**
Starbucks touted some of its cups as "widely recyclable," but none of the ones tracked by an advocacy group reached a recycling facility. **A12**

STYLE

Some loyal fans of Everlane are feeling betrayed by the clothing brand's sale to fast-fashion titan Shein. **B1**

SPORTS

At a Brooklyn bar, Zohran Mamdani, Spike Lee and thousands of other sports fans come together. **C1**

THE REGION

More than 100 years ago, Black residents fled a Virginia island. A move by descendants to reclaim their history opened old wounds. **C7**

HEALTH & SCIENCE

More than half of teens are losing vital sleep to school-night phone use, a new study finds. **D1**

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The Washington Post
Year 149, No. 54592

